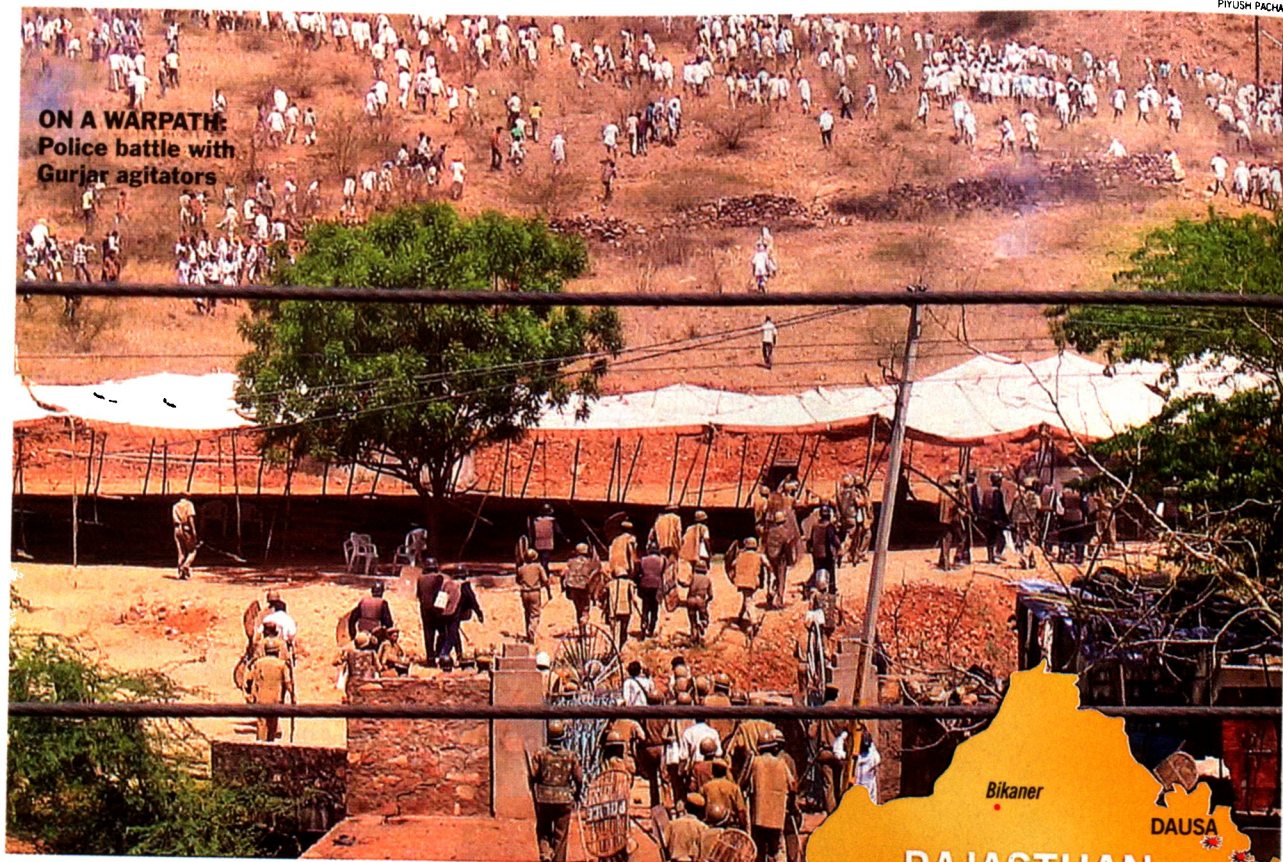




CASTE IN CONFLICT

The violent Gurjar agitation for Scheduled Tribe status can erupt into a serious crisis if rival castes, not willing to share benefits, retaliate



■ By Rohit Parihar

Once again, India's bubbling caste cauldron has spilled over into violence, arson, destruction of public property and loss of life. The statistics say it all: 14 dead, including two policemen, hundreds injured, public property worth lakhs damaged, vehicles and buses set on fire and a strategic highway dug up. The army had to be called out to control the frenzied crowds. While media focused on the role of the police and excessive use of force, at the core of the confrontation lies a battle for political power.

The caste warriors this time were the Gurjars in Rajasthan, traditionally a shepherd community, now engaged in a violent agitation demanding

Scheduled Tribe status. Their leader is Kirori Singh Bainsla, a retired army colonel. Settled in Hindon, a non-descript town in Karauli district, he became head of the Gurjar Arakshan Sangharsh Samiti three years ago. Last week, thousands of Gurjars converged around Jaipur and blocked the national highways. Near Dausa, they dug up long stretches using JCB machines.

The Gurjars are already listed as Backward Class, but seeing the employment advantages and political power that Scheduled Tribes (ST) like Meenas have earned in Rajasthan, they too have been demanding ST status. The demand was initially rejected by the Congress government in 1981. Even the BJP government has not pushed their case.

Unlike reservation status for Other Backward Classes (OBC) which is done both at state and Central level, a caste can be included in the SC and ST category only through the Centre's recommendation since it calls for a parliamentary amendment in the existing list. The state's role is limited to making a recommendation which is based on reports obtained from district collectors. This is verified by the Centre which may approve or reject a recommendation. In the case of the Gurjars, the Rajasthan Government had started the process and obtained reports from 26 of the 32 district collectors. INDIA TODAY has learnt that most of these reports diluted the community's chances of getting ST status. The Government then sent back reports of six districts, where Gurjars are concentrated, to the collectors for clarifications. The exercise, meant to be completed by July 31,